



The Way My Girlfriend Looked At Him

Taken Erotica

JJ Vale

The Way My Girlfriend Looked at Him

Taken erotica

JJ Vale

PMI

Copyright © 2026 JJ Vale

All rights reserved

The characters and events portrayed in this book are fictitious. Any similarity to real persons, living or dead, is coincidental and not intended by the author.

No part of this book may be reproduced, or stored in a retrieval system, or transmitted in any form or by any means, electronic, mechanical, photocopying, recording, or otherwise, without express written permission of the publisher.

I buzzed him in and left the door cracked.

Talia peeked around the kitchen doorway, wiping her hands on a dish towel. “That him?” She was excited and nervous at the same time. I had told her too many stories about Darren.

“Yeah,” I said and I smirked. I knew the effect he had on women and Talia wasn’t used to guys like him. I thought it would be funny — he was 6-4 and built like a wide receiver. She would never expect a guy like him would be a friend of mine.

She nodded like she was super casual about it and nothing bothered her, but she adjusted her ponytail in the hall mirror and tugged her sleeves down to her wrists. The hoody she wore was soft, pale grey, and her bike shorts were tight, her usual around the home outfit.

I opened the door fully when I heard the stairs creak. Darren came up with a gym bag over his shoulder and a wide grin. It wasn’t his first time he’d shown up halfway across the country with nowhere to stay.

“Still ugly I see,” he said, stepping in.

“Still homeless,” I said.

We clapped shoulders. He dropped the bag inside the door and looked past me.

Talia smiled politely from down the hallway and stepped up from behind me. “Hey.”

“Hey back. Darren.” He held out a hand.

She shook it lightly, then tucked her hands deep in her hoody pocket, stretching it down over the front of her body. “I’m Talia, but I’m sure you already know that,” she said, and she chuckled and rolled her eyes. She nudged my shoulder with hers.

“Appreciate the couch,” he said.

I smirked at him and shook my head. Same old Darren I thought, and I shut the door.

“No worries,” Talia replied. “You want a beer?”

“God, yes.”

She turned for the fridge. Darren's eyes stayed on her for half a second longer than he should have allowed himself. I think Talia surprised him, too. He wasn't expecting me to be with someone like her.

He always got away with those long stares. Even back in college, he never rushed the glance but left it on them long enough to make them wonder if he was thinking something he shouldn't say. But with a guy like him, none of them seemed to mind too much.

Talia handed him a bottle and leaned back on the counter playing it all cool and relaxed.

I watched her, not him, fascinated at her transformation, amused by it.

"You still doing that physical therapy stuff?" I said.

"Yep. High-end sports clinic now. In Boulder."

"You like it?"

"I like working on bodies," he said, then he smirked at Talia. "Knees, man. Nobody takes care of their knees," he said back to me and he shook his head with his lips pursed. But he was still grinning.

Talia laughed a bit more than just politely. "That's so true," she said to me, kicking me to make me look. "My clients are always tearing something. I'm in massage," she said back to Darren, "not PT, but same idea."

"Oh yeah? Nice. Massage."

She opened her mouth like she might say more, then closed it and looked down. I had no idea what she meant for me when she nudged me.

We moved to the living room after a quick bite. Darren stretched out on the end of the couch, one arm behind his head. Talia curled up in the middle with her legs under her, the hem of her hoody resting on bare thigh. I sat at the other end, half watching the movie and half tracking the energy between them. It was interesting, it was captivating, him surprised at her, and her showing me a side of herself that I'd not seen before. What was it? Showing off? Inspiration?

Darren laughed at something on screen and Talia glanced at him and laughed too. But not at the joke, at him. I bulged my eyes and pulled my chin in. Her eyes seemed to sparkle and it made me smirk. She wasn't hiding much.

The movie played on, something with too much dialogue and dim lighting. I kept waiting for the plot to kick in, but it seemed to never come.

Talia shifted beside me, tucked a throw pillow between her knees, and stretched her hoody down, even though it still barely reached past her

shorts. Darren didn't say much. He sipped his beer, the bottle resting against his chest, eyes on the screen like he was alone in the room.

"You ever seen this one?" I asked.

He didn't look away. "Nah. Feels like one of those movies where nobody smiles for two hours and then someone dies in the rain."

Talia snorted, then covered her mouth like she hadn't meant to laugh so hard. "It won a bunch of awards," she said, defensively.

Darren glanced over at her, eyes lazy. "I like your laugh better than the movie. You should be in it."

She blinked then looked down and tucked her feet under the pillow. Did I detect a blush? I felt her leg press lightly against mine. She was nudging me again.

Darren took another sip and sank down further to let his head fully rest back against the couch cushion. Everybody was getting more relaxed, which was good. I thought Talia would find Darren too much and too loud, and Darren would find Talia too conservative and too quiet. But that wasn't true at all.

Twenty minutes passed, everyone quiet except for the occasional comment. Darren's phone lit up and he ignored it. Talia got up during a slow scene and padded into the kitchen without saying a word. The hem of her shorts rode up as she reached into the cupboard for popcorn, the neckline of her hoody sliding off her shoulder to show the black straps of her bra.

She brought the bowl to the couch. Darren reached in and their hands brushed, but neither of them mentioned it, they just glanced at each other and smiled lightly.

The scene on screen shifted to something somber, a funeral or maybe a dream. I wasn't watching anymore. Darren's hand went back into the bowl, slower this time, fingers trailing against the inside edge. Talia didn't move. She held the bowl on her lap, one hand resting lightly against the curve of it, the other pressed beneath the pillow between her knees. She seemed distracted.

"Cold in here?" Darren asked, not looking at her.

"A little," she said, barely above a whisper.

I reached for the remote. "I'll turn the heat up."

Darren stretched his legs out and looked over his shoulder. "You don't have to. I'll grab a top in a bit."

“I’m fine,” Talia added quickly.

She pulled the sleeves of her hoody down to her knuckles, then tucked her chin in like she was settling in for good.

I threw a blanket over her lap anyway. I stayed a few minutes longer but my eyes were heavy. When I got up to go brush my teeth, Talia looked up at me and smiled gently.

“You going to bed?” she asked.

“Yeah. I’m wiped.”

“Okay,” she said, eyes soft. “I might finish this one.”

I was now officially shocked, but I didn’t show it. Talia choosing to remain alone with one of my friends, let alone with Darren, was a big step for her.

Darren didn’t say anything but he also didn’t move. They were nearly leaning on each other. The couch they sat on together was already designated as his bed.

In the bathroom, I left the door open and the light off, letting the dim hallway glow guide me. I brushed my teeth slowly, not because I was tired, but because I didn’t want to go back out there, not yet. Their voices drifted in faintly from the living room, low and conversational, with no urgency in them at all. I loved that they were getting along so well.

I caught the rise and fall of Talia’s voice, soft and smooth, followed by Darren’s deeper response. I couldn’t make out the words, but I could hear the shape of their conversation. She was asking him something, not rhetorical or polite, something she actually wanted to know. When he answered, she laughed with real amusement.

When I turned off the faucet, the apartment had fallen quiet again. Their voices had stopped. I waited, listening, but there was only the hum of the fridge and the faint buzz of the show still playing in the background.

I crossed to the bedroom, the floor cool beneath my feet. The room was dark, lit only by the hallway light. I got under the blankets but stared up at the ceiling, eyes open, thoughts circling the way they always did when I had things to think I didn’t want in my head.

I didn’t know how much time passed before I noticed she still hadn’t come to bed. I turned onto my side, reached out instinctively, and touched the empty half of the mattress. The sheet was undisturbed, no indentation, no warmth. Nothing to suggest she’d been back at all.

I must have slept. I sat up and let my eyes adjust.

The apartment felt different, like something subtle had shifted in the air while I had been sleeping. I got up and moved back into the hallway, slower because I didn't want to be seen.

The living room glowed faintly from the television screen, now showing music videos, the music on light. Talia was still on the couch but curled into the blanket with her knees pulled up and her head resting on the cushion. She looked asleep, or close to it, her face turned slightly toward the screen, one hand under her cheek.

Darren was stretched out beside her, his long legs bent slightly and one arm resting against the back cushion and thrown around her shoulders. His eyes were closed, but his breathing was light. It was not the deep kind of breathing that came with sleep.

I stood in the hallway for a longer moment, unnoticed and unmoving before I turned back to the bedroom.

I left the door open when I lay back down but I wasn't sure why. Maybe I wanted to hear something, maybe I wanted to leave a trace of my presence, maybe the sound of my breathing down the hall could serve as a boundary. A boundary against what?

The sheets were warm. I lay still and tried to find a rhythm in the quiet, but everything felt suspended. The apartment wasn't asleep but it felt like it was waiting.

A sound came from the living room, subtle enough that I almost missed it, the soft rustle of fabric shifting against fabric. It was a slow repositioning of weight, like someone moving carefully to avoid being heard.

I closed my eyes to sharpen the rest of my senses. My mind played games on me like this all the time. I had no reason ever to question Talia.

The television volume had been turned up at some point. I could barely hear the occasional creak of the couch. I heard what might have been Darren clearing his throat, barely audible, followed by the whisper of the blanket being moved.

There was another pause. Then a new sound, quiet but distinct. Was it the wet click of lips parting? Was it a breath that caught and softened? Not speech, not laughter, but something smaller and more private.

I opened my eyes and stared into the darkness. There was a tightening in my chest, but not the kind I expected. It wasn't just jealousy. It wasn't even betrayal, not yet anyway. It was something else entirely, something lower, heavier, and more complex. I wasn't certain what I wanted to be true and

what I wanted to be only my imagination. I only knew I wanted to understand what was going on out there, and why Talia wasn't in bed yet.

I pushed the blanket aside and sat up slowly. My feet touched the floor without making a sound. Half of me believed I would stand, walk to the hallway, and end the tension. The other half knew I wouldn't do that because I didn't want to stop it, what might have been happening out there. And that was a strange thing to feel.

I wanted to know what Talia might actually do if she thought I had gone to sleep. Not because I didn't trust her, but because I had seen something in her that evening that didn't match the girl I thought I knew. I wanted to know more.

She was still the quiet, gentle, warm being I always knew. But beneath that, there was a new current as though something was waking up inside her.

Darren had seen it. He didn't chase it. He didn't flirt. But he watched her with the kind of attention that made her stand taller, speak more carefully, smile with a trace of new certainty. She responded to him not with coyness or guilt, but with a kind of curiosity, and that was new.

I lay back down and pulled the blanket up and waited for whatever came next.

I didn't fall asleep. I just remained still and aware, breathing in the dark. If they were talking, it was only in glances, in motion. At some point, I must have blinked longer than I meant to, because the next sound I heard snapped me awake and straight into alertness.

Talia had never cheated at anything in her life. She used to apologize when her phone buzzed during dinner because it felt rude to check it while we were eating. Her bras matched her panties even when no one would ever see them, like she believed there was a right way to be dressed underneath. She kissed me slowly every morning, even when she was running late, and always made sure she was the last to break it off.

And yet the version of her that seemed to exist just down the hallway didn't belong to that list of habits.

Something had changed. And the worst part, the part I wasn't ready to admit to myself, was that I had felt it coming. Not just tonight and not just since Darren arrived, but longer than that. There had been something rippling just under the surface of her attention, something I couldn't say but that showed up in the way she touched her own neck while she read, or how

she sat on the balcony with her thighs exposed to the sun and her eyes closed like she wanted someone to see her.

Maybe it had nothing to do with Darren, maybe he was just the first man close enough to catch it.

The couch creaked again, low and rhythmic, barely perceptible unless you were listening for it. It didn't sound like shifting for comfort, it sounded like restraint.

I stayed perfectly still. In that moment, the sick part of me, the part I hadn't known existed until now, realized I didn't want to interrupt it. I didn't want to know for sure, not yet. She wasn't the only one changing.

I wanted her to do it, I wanted her to go farther. Not because I wanted to lose her, but because I needed to see who she really was when I wasn't looking. I wanted Talia to do what she wanted.

I closed my eyes and listened harder. The next sound I heard was the unmistakable whisper of skin against skin, no fabric involved at all this time.

It was slow and measured. Controlled, like someone easing their way into a moment they'd imagined first and now didn't want to rush. It was the sound of someone trying very hard to not make any sound.

Then I heard her breathe in sharply through her teeth, and hold it.

Talia's POV

I could hear him breathing slow and evenly beside me though we both stared straight ahead at the show.

Darren hadn't moved for a while, at least, not in any way that said he was awake. His arm was still slung casually over the back of the couch, fingers draped over my shoulder, his hand now sliding to hang loosely down the front of me. He had stretched out the way you do when you went to bed, but I hadn't shifted away.

I told myself it was fine. We weren't even touching, not really. Certainly not in a way that meant anything.

The television had dimmed to that soft, idle glow, casting the room in a flickering blue. It painted blue the floor, the edges of his chest, the inside of my thighs where the blanket had slipped. I hadn't meant to fall into this position with him, half-curved in, back pressed to the cushion, hips angled toward him.

I had meant to go to bed. I had even stood up at one point, holding the edge of the blanket, but he looked over at me and smiled, and something about the way he remained still made me want to sit back down.

He didn't reach for me and he didn't even flirt with me. He just stayed where he was and let me decide how close I wanted to be. That was what made it worse. Or maybe better.

"I can't tell if you're asleep yet," I whispered.

His head turned slightly toward me. He didn't open his eyes, but his voice was low and quiet.

"I'm not and you know that."

I felt my breath catch. Not because I was afraid, but because something about hearing him say that, his voice so soft, and with no suggestion in it, unlocked the part of me I had been trying to keep down the last few weeks or months.

I let the blanket fall away from my arms. My skin prickled in the air, but I didn't pull the fabric back up. I wasn't cold.

The soft cotton of my hoody clung lightly to the shape of my breasts. I had chosen the bra for comfort, but it was still one of my pretty ones, deep wine-colored lace with a satin edge that peeked just faintly along the neckline. The straps were thin and matched the waistband of the panties underneath. I never thought anyone would see them tonight, I wear things like that just for me. I wasn't sure if I wanted him to see, but I wasn't sure I didn't. That's the part that was coming unlocked in me.

"You're quiet," he said, still not looking directly at me.

"I'm just thinking," I murmured.

"What about?"

I hesitated. Then I pulled my legs up onto the couch, folding them beneath me, letting my thigh brush his leg, not hard, but enough to be felt.

"I'm not even sure."

He smiled faintly, eyes still closed. "Okay then."

He didn't move away. I looked down at my hands resting in my lap. My nails traced the hem of my top, pulled it higher until the smooth band of my waistband was exposed in the flickering light.

I didn't stop. I didn't look at him when I slid my fingers under the hem of my hoody. I let the fabric gather as I pulled upward, slow enough to feel the cool air meet each inch of my skin. My stomach tensed automatically, not

from fear, but from the quiet pressure of being seen, even if his eyes were still closed.

I wanted to be seen.

The fabric passed over my bra, lifting against it, catching for a moment along the strap before I raised it higher. I paused at my ribs, holding the bunched cotton against my chest, half-covered and fully aware of it. The movement had made my breathing shallow.

He still hadn't opened his eyes. Or maybe he had, and I wasn't brave enough to look.

I pulled the hoody off in one smooth motion, letting it fall beside the couch cushion. The air touched my shoulders, then the tops of my breasts, and I felt the lace of my bra contract slightly as I exhaled. It wasn't the chill that made me breathe that way.

My legs shifted on the cushion. My thighs pressed together and then relaxed again, spreading just enough for my knees to angle outward under the blanket, which now only covered the lower half of my legs.

I traced the inside of my wrist with my thumb, as if steadying myself, but my attention was on the smooth line of his chest, the slow movement of his breath, the curve of his shoulder in the television light.

His head tilted toward me.

"You still busy thinking?"

His voice was lower now, and the way he said it wasn't playful, it was careful and measured.

I nodded, then realized he couldn't see it. "Yes."

His eyes opened then. Not fully, just enough for me to see the dark shape of them watching me. He didn't look down and he didn't let his gaze trail. He just looked directly into my eyes and somehow that made me more aware of my body than if he had stared at my chest.

My fingers moved to the waistband of my shorts. I didn't yank them and I didn't make a show of it. I simply lifted my hips an inch and slid the fabric down over my hips, inch by inch, watching him the entire time to see if he would look away.

He didn't.

The shorts slipped past my thighs, down over my knees, and gathered at my ankles. I kicked them off and let them rest on the floor. My legs settled back onto the couch, bare now except for the deep wine panties that

matched the bra, scalloped edges, delicate mesh, the kind of set I wore only ever for myself.

Except tonight, I didn't feel like behaving just for me anymore.

He didn't reach for me. That would have been easier, if he had taken control, if he had made the first move. I could have let it happen without owning it. But Darren stayed exactly where he was, eyes on mine, breath steady, hands resting against the cushion like he had no intention of breaking the wall unless I did.

He forced me to decide. I could have pulled the blanket up. I could have stood. I could have whispered goodnight and gone to bed.

Instead, I moved closer. Just a few inches at first, enough for my knees to brush against his thigh. My skin met his through the fabric of his shorts, and even that minimal contact sent something warm down my spine. I didn't pull away, but I waited, yet he still didn't touch me.

He only said one thing. "Are you sure?"

I almost laughed, but it caught in my throat. Not because it was funny, but because it sounded like something from a different version of this night, one where I wasn't already half-undressed, sitting beside him in matching fancy lingerie, my chest rising faster than I wanted him to see.

I nodded slowly.

Then I reached for his hand. It felt heavy in my grip. His fingers were long, warm, a little rough. I pulled them toward me and placed them on my thigh just above the knee. I didn't guide him higher and I didn't push. I just left him there, palm against bare skin, feeling the weight of that contact settle into the space between us.

His hand remained still for a moment, as though absorbing the moment. Then his thumb began to move, slowly tracing along the inside of my thigh, pressing gently in a path back and forth with no urgency, no escalation. He let his touch become familiar before it became anything else.

I exhaled and closed my eyes. The muscles in my legs responded immediately, not with tension, but with that slow, melting heat that started in the deepest part of my stomach. My hips shifted forward by instinct and the edge of the cushion met me differently now, more pressure where I wanted none, more resistance than I was ready to admit I was chasing.

His fingers never left my skin. They didn't rush and they didn't prod, they only circled and smoothed, a quiet exploration just beneath the surface of what I'd let him see.

When his fingertips moved an inch higher, I didn't stop him. I didn't even open my eyes.

The moment his fingers brushed the edge of my panties, I felt everything tighten.

Not out of fear, or shame, but because I had never been touched like this without being kissed, without being held, without anything to announce what was starting.

There was something terrifyingly intimate about how quiet it was. His fingertips moved along the fabric, slowly tracing the curve where the lace met my skin. He wasn't exploring blindly, he wasn't trying to get somewhere. He was feeling me, mapping the line of my body through touch alone.

I shifted my hips an inch forward, just enough for the cushion to give. The fabric of the panties grew tighter against me, drawing more awareness to every slight movement. My breathing was no longer steady. Each inhale dragged through my nose, shallow and uneven, and I knew he could hear it, too.

He didn't look at my face. His eyes were on my stomach, on his own hand, on the way my skin moved under his fingers. There was no smirk, no expression of possession, only attention and focus.

The edge of his thumb moved lower, pressing lightly against the center seam of the fabric. He didn't slip beneath it, he only applied the slightest pressure, enough for the sensation to land. My body answered without my control. I felt the heat rise sharply, not just between my legs, but across my chest, up the sides of my neck, into my scalp.

He dragged his hand back slowly, retracing the same line down my thigh. When it returned, the touch was firmer, more deliberate, two fingers now following the path, then flattening to press against the mound of fabric between my legs.

The lace was warm and damp with arousal I hadn't consciously noticed. When his palm pressed down, the mesh clung tighter. The contact wasn't invasive, it was encompassing. Every part of me beneath it responded at once.

My mouth parted, but no sound came. His hand paused, but not in hesitation but rather in acknowledgment that he felt it too.

I opened my eyes and looked at him. He met my gaze calmly, not questioning, not daring, but watching.

I heard something in the hallway and twisted around. He pulled his hand away and I stared into the half-open bedroom door, but Eli was sound asleep in there. I brought his hand back to me.

His fingers moved again, this time with purpose. Not hard and not rushed but with enough pressure to slide along the wet lace, drawing a slow, careful line. He used the heel of his palm to press down while his fingers circled, coaxing more heat from me, pulling sensation from deep inside me and spreading it outward.

I pressed my thighs together around his hand, not to stop him, but to feel him more fully. The pressure amplified everything, made my pulse roar in my ears, made my hips tilt up toward his touch.

Still, he didn't push past the fabric. He kept his hand still for one breath, then two. The weight of it settled low against me, his fingers relaxed, the heat of his palm radiating through the thin mesh. I felt the shape of him, broad across my lower belly, the pads of his fingers resting against the line of my lips through the fabric, and I wanted him to move again, but I didn't say it. I only shifted my hips a fraction forward, letting the signal speak clearly for me.

His fingers slid down slowly, following the damp center of my panties, pressing just enough to part me beneath the fabric. The motion wasn't rushed, and it wasn't clumsy. He explored like he already knew what he'd find, like he had been imagining this exact feeling and wanted to check whether it matched what he'd pictured.

When his fingertips reached the edge of the lace, he paused. He didn't speak and he didn't look at me. He only lifted the fabric gently, running his fingers under the waistband, and began to slip beneath it.

The contact was immediate. His touch met bare skin for the first time, and every nerve answered at once. I inhaled through my teeth and held the breath in my chest. His fingers moved lower, not deep, just enough to find the wetness that had already spread along the edge of my opening. He lingered there, easing through it, gathering it slowly, his hand cupped against me in a way that made my thighs tighten, shake.

I didn't resist. I let my legs spread just slightly, welcoming the contact without asking for more. His fingertips dragged up between my folds with excruciating slowness, careful not to go inside, not even to press too hard. He stayed shallow, letting me feel the contrast, how delicate it was, how precise, how completely in control of my body he was.

My hands had drifted to my thighs without me realizing. I dug my nails lightly into the skin, not to brace, but to stay centered. My whole body had gone warm. My breasts ached inside the bra, full and tight, nipples stiff against the lace. I wanted to be touched there too, but I didn't want to lose what he was doing.

When his thumb found my clit, he didn't circle it. He only pressed once, gently, holding the contact for a breath. The sensation hit me hard, hot, sharp, almost unbearable in how restrained it was. Then he pulled his hand back slowly, dragging through every inch again on the way down, not retreating but reinforcing everything he had just touched.

I let out a breath I didn't know I was holding.

He didn't speak and neither did I.

I leaned back against the couch cushion letting my shoulders settle deeper into it, my body open beneath him now. The panties were still in place, barely, stretched taut from where he'd slipped under, but the rest of me felt uncovered, exposed in ways that had nothing to do with fabric.

His hand drifted down again, then paused, resting lightly against the inside of my thigh. I knew what he was waiting for. He let me decide every step.

I reached behind my back without saying anything. The clasp was small, familiar, and my fingers found it easily. I hesitated but only once, just a flicker of pause, maybe even a tease, before I unhooked it.

The bra loosened. The straps slipped from my shoulders and slid down my arms, catching briefly on my elbows before I let it fall to the side. I didn't toss it or fold it. I just let it go. My arms dropped back to my sides, and I remained still.

The air met my skin instantly, cool against the heat that had built across my chest. I could feel how hard I'd become, nipples tight, aching, the whole weight of my breasts sensitized. Every shift made them move differently now, no longer held in place. I was conscious of how they sat, how they rose with each breath, how exposed I felt even in the dim flicker of the television.

Darren didn't reach immediately. His gaze moved over me, not leering, not devouring, just taking it in, like he had waited for this view long enough that he didn't want to blink through it.

Then his hand moved. He raised it slowly and brought his fingertips to my sternum, just below the base of my neck. From there, he traced down

between my breasts, not touching them directly, not yet, just outlining the path his hands might take if I didn't stop him. And I didn't stop him.

When his palm finally cupped my right breast, the warmth of it made me shiver. He held it fully, not squeezing, just letting it fill his hand. His thumb brushed across the tip, then again, and the sensation sent a pulse of arousal straight down through my stomach. My back arched. The second time he circled it, slower now, my lips parted and I exhaled audibly.

He leaned in then, finally breaking the space between us, not with his mouth, but with both hands.

His other hand found my left breast and mirrored the motion, palms steady, thumbs grazing in quiet rhythm. He wasn't playing with me, he was learning me, testing how I reacted, what made me tense, what made me melt.

My thighs tightened again and I could feel how wet I had become. It was no longer possible to pretend this was still only in the realm of suggestion.

His hands left my chest without urgency. He trailed them down my sides as he moved, letting his fingertips skim along the curve of my waist, past my hips, and lower, until they rested against the inside of my thigh again. The skin there felt hypersensitive now, warmed, exposed, waiting.

I was already parted. He had done that earlier without taking anything from me. He had only touched, only explored. But the ache had grown worse since then. My body wasn't tense, it was ready. Everything in me leaned into the moment. There was no space left for doubt.

He slid his hand back between my legs. The panties clung wetly to me, the lace slick where it had pressed against the center. He didn't hesitate this time. His fingers slipped beneath the fabric, and when he reached the warm slickness underneath, he exhaled through his nose, low and quiet.

His touch was more certain now. He didn't move quickly, but he moved with intent.

I felt one finger glide along the length of me, slow and steady, parting everything again with just enough pressure to open me. The heat there was undeniable, the wetness more than enough. He circled once at the top, dragging the sensation upward, before dipping lower.

When he entered me, he did it carefully. My body answered instantly. I tightened around him, my hips shifting down and forward to meet the motion, and I felt the length of his finger press inward, knuckle by knuckle,

until it was fully inside me. The stretch was subtle, but I felt every inch of it, every pulse, every twitch of muscle in response.

He paused once he was in, giving me time, letting me feel it. Then he began to move, slow and rhythmic. Each withdrawal was gentle, followed by the slow push back in. My thighs opened farther to allow him. I didn't even think about the motion, my body made room for him on its own.

His other hand slid back to my hip, anchoring me, holding me in place while he worked. The rhythm was calm and controlled. There was no rushing with him, no force. Just a steady, gliding pressure that grew warmer with each pass. He curved his finger slightly on the next thrust, and I gasped, not from pain, but from the sudden brightness of sensation deep inside me.

My mouth opened, but nothing came out.

He curved again, slower this time, testing the angle. I tilted my hips up to meet it, pressing against his palm, and I could feel my own wetness spreading down to the back of his hand.

Then a second finger joined the first. I was already lifting my hips for him. The second finger slid in beside the first with a slow, steady pressure that filled me completely. My body yielded easily, but I still felt every new inch, how the stretch deepened, how the walls of my body wrapped tighter around him in response. The heat inside me pulsed with each movement, rising with a sharp clarity that narrowed my awareness to nothing but the places where we touched.

He kept his rhythm exact. Each stroke moved slowly, not pulling all the way out, not rushing back in. He stayed inside me, easing in deeper, adjusting the angle just slightly with each pass until he found the one that made my legs tremble. When his fingertips curled upward and pressed against the front of me, I arched my back in reflex. The breath I let out was broken, not from panic, but from how precisely he had found the spot that made everything tighten around him involuntarily.

I grabbed the edge of the cushion beside me, grounding myself, anchoring to something solid while my hips rocked forward and back. My skin burned with the tension building behind my ribs, low and heavy, tightening like a cord being pulled from somewhere beneath my navel.

He said nothing. His mouth stayed closed. His breath was quiet and steady, but was heavier now as his eyes followed every response I gave

him. There was no gloating in his expression, no smugness. Just that same calm certainty of his, now turned inward on me.

His thumb found my clit again, this time bare, slick, fully exposed. He didn't circle. He pressed lightly, holding the contact for two full strokes of his fingers inside me before he moved again. The pressure was perfect, soft at first, then firmer, never frantic. It matched the rhythm of what he was doing deeper inside me, drawing sensation from both directions and pushing it all toward the center of me.

My legs were shaking now with the kind of tremble that starts low and spreads outward when release is coming closer than you're ready for. I didn't want to let go yet. I wanted to stay inside the feeling, stay in the moment of being touched like this, held open and carefully explored, like my body was being read rather than used.

But I was already too close. The pressure was too exact, the motion too steady. My muscles pulled tighter with every thrust, my breathing short and open, mouth parted with no sound coming out.

He didn't change his pace. He didn't speed up or demand anything from me. He only kept going exactly as he was, letting my body decide the rest.

It didn't come as a crash. It was a long, rising wave that didn't stop when I thought it would, a heat that poured outward in slow, rolling pulses as my back arched and my eyes shut tight against the sensation taking hold of everything. I covered my mouth and clenched my eyes.

My body stayed arched for a moment, my hips lifting into his hand, thighs trembling as the last of the wave moved through me. The release had taken more from me than I expected. It didn't empty me, it left me wide open and full in a way that felt more physical than emotional. Every part of me still pulsed with the echo of it, even as my muscles slowly began to unclench.

I let my back sink into the cushion, my chest rising and falling in shallow waves, my arms limp at my sides. The air in the room felt different now, denser, warmer against my skin, or maybe it was just my skin that had changed. I could still feel the path his hands had taken on me, not as memory but as presence, as though my body had memorized the shape of him and now expected him to stay exactly where he was.

His fingers withdrew slowly. He didn't pull away with haste or hesitation. He moved with the same precision he had used to enter me, sliding out gently, letting my body close around the absence as it adjusted. I

felt the wetness spread slightly as he pulled free, the faint drag of his skin against mine, the soft brush of fabric as he pulled his hand clear of the panties.

My breath caught at the change, not in resistance, but in awareness. The cool air met me again between my legs, and I realized how soaked the fabric had become, how closely it clung to me now, how unmistakably exposed I would be if I stood.

He didn't speak. He wiped his hand lightly on the edge of the blanket and then placed it on my thigh again, this time just resting there. Not exploring, not requesting anything more, but holding contact while I came back into myself.

I opened my eyes and looked at him. He was watching me the same way he had before, still calm, still waiting. There was no triumph in his face, no pride in what he'd done to me, only the kind of attention that stays fixed on someone because it doesn't want to miss what comes next.

I reached down and adjusted my panties, smoothing them gently against my hips. They were damp enough to cling and the motion reminded me of what he had done, of what I had let him do, and of how completely I had wanted it.

His hand moved off my leg slowly as I sat up. I didn't speak. I only leaned forward resting my elbows on my knees, letting my hair fall forward while I caught my breath. My heart was still beating hard. I had let him inside me. And I wanted more.

I stayed forward for a few breaths, head lowered, eyes fixed on the carpet between my feet. My body still hummed with aftershocks, not from the orgasm itself, but from how controlled it had all been, how completely I had stayed aware the entire time, never taken, never pushed. I had chosen every second of it.

I sat upright and turned toward him.

He hadn't moved. His back was still pressed back against the couch, one hand resting loosely on his thigh, the other draped over the cushion behind him. His chest rose evenly and his eyes were on me.

I shifted toward him on my knees, crossing the cushion slowly, straddling his lap without hesitation but also without rushing. My thighs settled against his, knees pressing into the cushion on either side of his hips. The blanket slid down behind me, pooling at the small of my back. My chest was bare, still flushed, still sensitive from how he had touched me. The

damp panel of my panties pressed lightly against the front of his shorts. I felt the heat of him immediately.

He exhaled through his nose, not heavily, but with intention. His hands rose to my hips, not to pull me down, but to hold me there.

I moved first. Not grinding, not testing, just adjusting, rocking forward to press against him, letting the fabric between us stretch tight, my wetness pushing into the cotton, the shape of him pressing back into me.

His eyes closed halfway, and I watched the line of his jaw tighten.

“You feel that?” I asked quietly and I smiled. I felt the control now.

His thumbs flexed gently against my hips. “Yeah.”

I rocked forward again, slower this time. The heat between us had nowhere to go, no space left. I wasn’t teasing, I wasn’t playing. I was preparing myself for the next step, and I needed to feel him through every layer first, needed the drag, the resistance, the proof of how badly I wanted him.

His hands slid around to the small of my back, resting just above the waistband of my panties. He just held me there, letting me stay in control, letting me move the way I needed to.

I rolled my hips and the fabric shifted, caught, then smoothed. I could feel how hard he was, how completely ready, and I knew he felt how wet I still was. The sensation wasn’t soft. It was direct, saturated, and unavoidable.

I reached down between us and hooked my fingers in the waistband of his shorts. I didn’t pull yet, I just held them there. My breath touched his mouth when I spoke again.

“Do you want me to take these off?”

His answer came without pause. “Yes.”

I leaned back just enough to make room between our bodies, then slowly lowered my hands to the waistband of his shorts. The fabric was soft, worn from use, stretched slightly from how he sat beneath me. I hooked my fingers underneath and began to ease them down, watching the way his stomach tightened as I moved.

His erection pressed upward, barely contained, the waistband catching against it before sliding lower. I didn’t rush. I wanted to feel it pass beneath my fingers, wanted to take in how hard he already was before I even touched him skin to skin.

I watched his eyes as I worked the fabric down over his hips. He held my gaze the entire time. He didn't reach for me. He didn't lift his hips until I nudged him gently, and then he raised them just enough for the shorts to slide free.

He was bare now. Hard, thick, fully ready, the length of him exposed between us without anything left to hide. I had imagined what he'd look like, maybe not consciously, but now that I could see him, there was no room left for pretending I hadn't been curious.

I let my eyes stay on him, not for effect, not to tease, but because I needed to know what I was about to feel.

His cock rested against his stomach, smooth and dark and pulsing with heat. I placed one hand lightly on his thigh, just to steady myself, and shifted my weight forward again, letting the slick center of my panties press against him.

The contact made me exhale sharply through my nose. The soaked lace clung to me like a second skin. As I rocked forward, the wetness spread between us, dragging against the underside of him. The fabric added friction, texture, more sensation than I expected. I moved again, slower this time, tracing the length of him with the damp panel while he sat still, letting me use him the way I needed to.

His hands found my waist again. They held me with quiet pressure, not to guide, but to feel me move.

I pressed harder on the next pass, letting him slide between my folds through the fabric, letting the head of him catch slightly against the seam. I didn't lift. I didn't change the angle. I only shifted again, pressing more firmly, grinding slowly with a tension that made my thighs shake from the effort to stay controlled. I could keep an eye on the hallway and the dark bedroom straddling him this way.

Feeling safe, I reached down. I took the edge of the panties in two fingers and pulled them aside. I didn't take them off. I only opened myself.

Then I reached between us again, took him in my hand, and guided him forward. The head of him pressed against me flesh to flesh, warm and solid, held steady in my hand as I angled my hips forward. I guided him to the opening, barely parting, just enough to feel the weight of what was coming settle exactly where I needed it. The first touch was almost nothing, just skin to skin, wetness to heat, but it landed with the kind of force that made my whole body draw tighter around the anticipation.

I kept my eyes on his. He didn't move. He stayed exactly where I placed him, hands resting lightly on my hips, fingers curled against the waistband of the panties I hadn't taken off. His eyes didn't flicker. He didn't watch between us. He only watched me, waiting.

I began to lower myself. The head of him slipped inside with the faintest resistance. I stopped breathing. My mouth opened, not in surprise, but in quiet effort as I adjusted, as my body stretched to take him. The pressure wasn't sharp. It was slow and full, blooming from the inside as I sank lower, inch by inch, the weight of him easing into me.

I inhaled sharply through my teeth. My thighs trembled as I settled deeper. The stretch made every inch register. There was no sudden thrust, no jolt of impact, only a steady, thick glide as I took him fully inside me.

He felt heavier than I imagined he would, harder, more present than any touch I had known before. I felt the slide of him inside me like a line being drawn, slow and continuous, from the very edge of my body to the core of it. My hands gripped his shoulders.

His jaw was locked, chest rising slower now, breath heavy but controlled. He didn't pull me down. He didn't buck his hips to meet mine. He only let me take him at the exact pace I chose.

When I reached the base of him, I paused. I stayed still, hips lowered, thighs trembling with the effort to hold myself steady. The fullness was complete. There was nothing left to take in, and yet my body still pulsed around him, aching for movement, even as I held myself in that stillness just a few seconds longer.

I looked down at him. He hadn't closed his eyes and neither had I.

I started to move. I lifted my hips slowly, not pulling away completely, only high enough to feel the length of him slide through me with steady resistance. The drag was thick and deliberate, the muscles inside me clinging to every inch of him, reluctant to let him go. When I reached the point just before he slipped free, I paused and lowered myself down again, the motion just as slow, just as exact.

The stretch met me the same way it had before, deep, full, and impossible to ignore.

I exhaled through parted lips, the sound caught somewhere between breath and soundless moan. My body was beginning to move on its own now, not wild or frantic, but with the natural rhythm of someone who had waited long enough to know what she wanted and wasn't willing to rush it.

His hands held my hips gently, letting me set the pace. He didn't thrust upward. He didn't take control. He only moved in response to me, his fingers tightening each time I came back down on him, as if he couldn't help anchoring himself to the movement.

I rode him slowly. Each rise and fall pulled another wave of pressure through me, deep and centered. The friction was warm and constant, the wet heat of my body wrapping tightly around him, making every stroke feel heavier, deeper, more consuming than the one before. My thighs worked in quiet rhythm, each shift of muscle controlled, steady, never frantic.

The fabric of my panties had twisted around one thigh, still pulled aside, the waistband taut where his hands rested. The elastic bit into my skin, a subtle contrast to the smooth motion happening beneath it. My breasts moved with each thrust, heavy and flushed, the nipples stiff, brushing against his chest when I leaned forward into the motion.

His breath deepened beneath me. But there was tension now, real tension, in the way he looked at me, as if he had to focus on something outside of his body to keep himself from losing the control he'd given me.

I shifted the angle, leaning farther forward on the next stroke, letting him fill me differently, lower, thicker, pressing into a part of me that made my back arch involuntarily. I gasped and adjusted again, chasing it, testing the angle, and when I found it again, I stayed there, hips moving in smaller, tighter circles now, grinding as much as thrusting.

His hands slid higher on my waist, gripping me tighter. I kept the motion steady, rolling my hips forward in slow, deliberate circles, the weight of him deep inside me with each pass. I didn't lift now, I stayed low, grinding instead of rising, letting the pressure build where it landed hardest, the base of him pressing into me in a way that made my thighs tense and my breath catch with every slow rotation.

He was silent beneath me. But his hands had changed. His grip had tightened around my waist, fingers digging in now, not hard, but with enough pressure to make his need unmistakable. His jaw was clenched, lips parted slightly, and his eyes had fallen halfway closed, not from detachment, but from focus. He was holding back.

I leaned forward more, letting my breasts brush his chest, my hands planted against his shoulders for balance. The new angle made the pressure inside me sharper, more insistent. I rode the motion in tighter loops, hips moving with the rhythm of someone who no longer needed to be careful.

He cursed under his breath, low, almost soundless. His hands slid from my waist to my hips, then to my lower back, pulling me down tighter against him. I didn't resist. I let him take that much, let him press me flush to him as he began to move underneath me, not to take over, but to meet the rhythm I had set.

The thrusts were shallow at first, more reaction than control. I felt him swell inside me, the change subtle but unmistakable. His body was tensing under mine, breath shortening, movements becoming more urgent with each second.

I didn't speed up. I stayed right where I was, letting him thrust up into me while I moved just enough to keep him buried, to keep that wet, tight friction constant. The sensation inside me sharpened again, not toward climax, but toward the kind of unbearable tension that begged to stay suspended.

His head dropped back. His grip locked. He thrust once, deeper, and then again, slower, but with a full-body tremor behind it. His breath caught, chest rising hard against mine, and I felt the final shift in him just before it happened.

The last few strokes were jerking, involuntary, his hips bucking beneath me with no rhythm left. I stayed pressed down, letting him empty into me, letting the heat pulse through every part of where we were joined.

He didn't make a sound. He only exhaled, slow and ragged, hands still clutching my waist like he couldn't quite let go.

I stayed on him, not moving, not speaking, my body still wrapped tightly around his, both of us held in the same quiet place we had just crossed into.

I stayed straddled across his hips, not out of indecision, but because my body hadn't released its grip on him yet. He was softening inside me, the heat of him still present, the wetness between us growing heavier with each slow breath. His hands remained on my waist, no longer pulling, only resting now, the tension in them beginning to ease.

Neither of us moved. The television had gone black, the screen idle and waiting, casting only a dim ambient glow. The room felt still in a different way now, like it had absorbed everything we'd done and wasn't ready to let it go. I felt the weight of his thighs under mine, the slow rise and fall of his chest, the sheen of sweat cooling along the center of my back.

I lifted myself carefully. The withdrawal was thick and slow, my body reluctant to let go of the shape it had held. I felt the wetness slide between

my legs, warm and unmistakable, trailing down the inside of my thigh as I stepped back onto the floor. My panties were still pulled aside. I adjusted them quietly, easing the lace back into place, though the fabric clung damp and useless against me now.

He watched me as I moved. He didn't ask anything and he didn't reach for me.

I bent and picked up my hoody from the floor, pulled it over my head without rushing. My bra remained somewhere beneath the couch. I didn't look for it. I only smoothed the fabric down my sides and turned toward the bedroom.

The apartment was silent. The clock on the stove glowed 4:19.

I walked barefoot down the hall. Each step felt deliberate, not heavy, but anchored in a different kind of awareness now, an unfamiliar calm wrapped around something I hadn't fully processed yet.

The bedroom door was still cracked. I pushed it open.

Eli was asleep, turned toward my side of the bed. The room was darker than the rest of the apartment. I crossed to the edge and sat for a moment, watching him, listening to the rhythm of his breath.

He didn't stir.

I slid beneath the covers, my body still warm, still open. The scent of the couch, of sweat, of him, clung faintly to my skin. I faced away from Eli, curling one arm under the pillow, the other resting along the curve of my waist. The lace of the panties had dried slightly now, cooling against me.

I closed my eyes but I didn't sleep. I only listened to the quiet of our room, to the sound of his breath, and to the feeling of my own body, full and slow and completely changed.

I didn't look back toward the door.

Eli's POV

The light was already coming through the blinds when I opened my eyes. It was weak light, early, angled low across the sheets. I hadn't meant to fall asleep. I had stayed awake for hours after I heard her breathing change in the other room, after the couch creaked more. I told myself I'd wait until I was sure. I must've drifted off.

I turned onto my side. Talia was beside me.

She was on her stomach, one leg drawn up, her face turned away. The blanket had slipped down around her waist. Her hoody was bunched near her ribs and I could see the curve of her lower back above where her panties should have been, but they weren't on her now. She'd still been dressed when I left her on the couch.

I sat up slowly, careful not to wake her. I pulled on a T-shirt from the floor and walked barefoot down the hall.

The couch was messy, blanket half-off, one of the cushions sunken lower than the others. Darren's shorts were on the armrest. No sign of his shirt. A pillow lay on the floor where it must've fallen during the night. Looking at it, I caught sight of a strap of her bra, kicked under the couch. Darren was sprawled out over the cushions, his face crushed into the pillow that had been between Talia's legs, sleeping deeply.

I crossed to the kitchen. The counter held two glasses, one nearly empty, the other full and untouched. Lipstick on one, a faint smudge on the rim. The wine bottle was open but recorked, sitting askew like it had been done in a hurry.

I went back down the hallway. The bathroom light was off, the door slightly ajar. I stepped inside and saw them instantly. Her panties were on the edge of the hamper, not folded, not set down gently, just left there, one side dangling off the side like it had been dropped without thought. They appeared wet.

I stood in the bathroom for a full minute, staring into the hamper like it would offer an explanation. My hand was on the doorframe, the cool wood steady beneath my palm. My stomach felt hollow, but not from hunger. Not from anger either. I didn't know what I felt.

But I couldn't stop thinking about what I hadn't seen. And the fact that she'd come back to bed after, quietly and soft, curling beside me like nothing had happened.

I made coffee and went out on the balcony to look out over the waking city. The question I had to contemplate was, would I confront Talia about what I found? Would I confront Darren?

Or, the evil thought gripped me and wouldn't let me go, would I pretend I noticed nothing, and see what happens the next night?